HOW CONTEXTUALIZATION AND INDIGENIZATION ARE OCCURING IN THE MIDST OF A CHURCH PLANTING MOVEMENT AMONG A THERAVADA BUDDHIST PEOPLE

PRESENTED TO

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IN PARTIAL FULFILLMENT OF THE REQUIREMENTS FOR

THE SEMINAR ON WORLD RELIGIONS

BY

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DECEMBER 2006

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INTRODUCTION

There have been numerous papers and books written about contextualization among Theravada Buddhist peoples; however, very few have been written within the context of an actual multiplying movement of Theravada Buddhists coming to Christ. In this paper I will try to explain and analyze the key terms, concepts and ceremonies that new leaders in this Indigenous Church Planting Movement (CPM) are using to remove barriers and build bridges of understanding. At first I personally disregarded the use of certain terms and methods but now after understanding more about the Theravada Buddhist's worldview I not only agree but am writing this paper to defend the use of such terms. I believe that God is bringing a better understanding of the Theravada worldview to His Church. I also believe that He is bringing clarity to the process of evangelism among Theravadas because He is about to bring a great harvest among the Buddhist peoples of Myanmar.

METHODOLOGY

I will defend this indigenous movement's use of key terms by clarifying the history of Theravada Buddhism. I will also attempt describe the primary barriers and questions that Theravada Buddhists are raising during the evangelism and discipleship phases. It is my prayer that through this paper and through further discussions those of us involved in helping churches multiply among Theravada Buddhists will have a clearer understanding of how to reach the Buddhist world for Christ.

Contextualization is the attempt by outsiders to give a culturally relevant presentation of the gospel to insiders. Indigenization is the insider's decision about how they will obey Christ in their own ways and means, while still retaining the meaning of God's word. Although both contextualization and indigenization are biblical, indigenization should be

our goal.[1] Spending too much time on contextual issues can distract us from helping new church leaders to decide which biblical principles need to be applied in order to help churches to multiply in their context. I will elaborate on these definitions later on in this paper.

The basis of biblical contextualization and indigenization is loving, childlike obedience to Christ's commands. According to Christ, merely teaching people is not making disciples but is founding new believers on sand and not the rock.[2] In the illustration that summarizes the Sermon on the Mount, commonly known as "The Wise and Foolish Builders," the rock does not simply mean Christ himself, but is primarily obedience to His commands. Jesus explains how to make disciples when he says, "teach them to obey all my commands" (Matt. 28:20). Teachers who only teach and who do not call listeners to obey Christ, are foolishly establishing churches and believers on sand and not firmly on the *rock*. The *rock*, in this story is not merely, Christ, but obedience to all of Christ's commands. Matt. 7:24-28.

We need to be very careful attempting contextualization outside of a movement of multiplying churches, because it is inside a movement of obedience that the Holy Spirit corrects and best incarnates the word of God into cultures. New churches and their elders need to learn to discern between New Testament commands, apostolic practices, and human traditions. (see Appendix 1.)

Throughout history the most damaging syncretism has not come from obedient multiplying churches but from disobedient sterile churches. It also has come from liberal seminaries with professors who have a low view of the church. These theoreticians often think of themselves and their traditions above the truth of God's Word. Church Multiplication coach, George Patterson writes,

> A common but erroneous assumption that often leads to paralyzing policies,

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[1] David Garrison, In an email to me, Garrison, used Bill Smith's definition of indigenization as being related to be seperate from contextualization. "Indigenization trumps contextualization when churches spontaneously multiply, naturally."

_____ *Church Planting Movements; How God Is Redeeming a Lost World.* (Midlothian, Va: Wigtake Pub, 2004), 5. According to Garrison's definition of a CPM, "Church Planting Movement is, "A Rapid Multiplication of indigenous churches planting churches that sweeps through a people group or population segment."

[2] Holy Bible, NIV, Matthew 7:24-28.

> is that the fear that love of Christ and doctrinal purity will gradually grow weaker in a chain reaction of new churches—daughter churches, grand-daughters, great-granddaughters, and so on. The timid wonder, 'Won't false beliefs creep in?' The fear of corruption is normal. We want our children to be healthy; we want our new churches to be doctrinally sound. But the real source of sound doctrine is not human control but loyalty to Christ...Doctrinal error comes when churches put man's customs ahead of God's commands. [3]

The fear of bad doctrine or the fear of new believers returning to their idols can in itself, become an idol that many missionaries prostrate before instead of trusting the Spirit of Christ in the hearts of new obedient believers in multiplying church networks,

> According to Paul Hiebert, most Western missionaries from 1800 to 1950 failed to contextualize the gospel due to an assumption of Western superiority.
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> The primary consequences of this extensive pattern of non-contextualization were 1) the broad perception of non-believers that Christianity was a foreign Western religion, and 2) those who became Christians were often syncretistic in their faith because they could not discuss with missionaries the more difficult cultural problems they faced.

Since February 2004 the two Buddhist background men that I am currently coaching have seen over one hundred churches start to multiply. I believe that their movement is one of the best examples of indigenization in the Theravada Buddhist world. This movement has already spilled over into the majority *Bhama* (Burmese) people as well as two other smaller Theravada Buddhist peoples and even among a Muslim people.

OVERVIEW OF THE BUDDHIST WORLD

In this paper I will be using the Theravada terms, *Nibbana* and *Gotama.* The two spellings *Nirvana* and *Gautama* are Sanskrit based, which is the religious language of the Mahayana school (also known as *Northern* Buddhism). Theravada Buddhists (also known as *Southern* Buddhists) number around 144 million people in the world today, with 86 people groups still considered unreached by evangelical mission agencies. Theravadas (school of the elders) can be found in Myanmar (Burma), Sri Lanka, Thailand, Cambodia, Laos, southern

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[3] George Patterson, *Church Multiplication Guide: the Miracle of Church Reproduction* (Pasadena: William Carey, 2002), 16.

[4] Don Dent, "Contextual Ministry to Muslims," (unpublished paper, Malaysia Baptist Seminary, 08/01/06), 14.

Vietnam, Yunnan Province in southwest China, among certain Hokkien Chinese populations of Malaysia, and in the Chittagong Division of southeastern Bangladesh.

Mahayana Buddhism is the primary religion in Japan, Korea, certain segments of Han Chinese communities, and Northern Vietnamese. This accounts for 520 million adherents and includes 23 people groups.[5] Mahayana is by far the best known sect of Buddhism in Western countries not only because of its size but also because it has more in common with the Christian worldview of salvation by grace through faith.

Sociologist Thom Wolf and Lucknow University Professor of Philosophy, Ahmad Shah, theorize that the Mahayana school started as a Buddhist reaction to the gospel message that the Apostle Thomas brought to western India. Thomas preached in the area where the Mahayana school founder, Asvaghosha, started his reformation of the Theravada school in 200 AD.[6] Buddhist world missiologist, Alex Smith, points out that Buddhists have a pattern of copying Christian mission strategies and employing successful methods such as Sunday School and theological education training.[7]

Since Mahayana is so vastly different from Theravada, mission strategies to reach Mahayanists have been completely different than effective strategies with Theravadas. Efforts to reach these two branches cannot be lumped together into the same category.

A third School of Buddhism is the Tantric branch, which is more popularly known as *Tibetan* Buddhism. This is the smallest branch and numbers about 16 million adherents but has the largest number of unreached 129 peoples.[8] Tibetan Buddhism is primarily

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[5] Paul Hattaway, 2004; *Peoples of the Buddhist.* (Pasadena, Ca, Piquant Editions Ltd. Carlisle, CA William Carey Pub. Waynesboro, GA), xxii.

In an interview with Evangelical Covenant missionary Paul DeNeui, defines syncretism as "dual-allegiance." Chiang Mai, Thailand, 2003.

[6] Shah, E. Ahmad, *Buddhism and Christian Faith,* ed. Thomas Wolf, (Lucknow, India: Lucknow Publishing House, 1973/1997), pp. 20-33, 53-74.

[7] Hattaway, 204.

[8] Hattaway, xii.

practiced in Nepal, Western China, Mongolia, in various parts of Russia, and India. There has been tremendous success among the Tantric Buddhist Newari people of Nepal in the past five years with thousands of believers currently being discipled in networks of multiplying house churches. In the early 1990s, a YWAM team led by Brian Hogan saw numerous churches start to multiply in central Mongolia. These new Mongolian churches are spreading the message of Christ, "the Khan of Khans" as far as Afghanistan and all the way to Thailand!

There have been numerous missiological breakthroughs and Church Planting Movements among Mahayanans in the past. Nearly ten percent of the Han Chinese are believers in the Lord Jesus Christ. Before Buddhism was introduced and Confucianism developed in China, the Han had knowledge of God whom they called, *Shang di* (the Emperor of Heaven). This aided greatly in the breakthroughs in Chinese People Movements. The thirty percent of Koreans who are now Christians call the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, *Hanna-nim,* which means "the First God." Confucian thought, which held the ancient writings as sacred withstood Mahayana Buddhism's eradication of the memory of the Most High God in the Korean and Chinese worldviews.[9] In the Theravada (school of the elders) view of Buddhism, a priest-craft has developed which has almost erased all memory of the Most High God therefore mission efforts among this branch has been an uphill climb. The Church has sent waves and waves of Christian missionaries to the shores of Theravada Buddhist countries but has seen THE LEAST success in comparison to mission efforts in the previous mentioned branches of Buddhism.

Even though there has been the least success, God has not left Himself without a witness and is still calling out a people for His name among Theravada Buddhist. The Sinhalese Church of Sri Lanka has the largest number among Theravadas with 620 thousands believers. The next largest groups of believers are the Central Thai of Thailand and the Khmer of Cambodia, each with 100,000 Christians.[10] The greatest growth among the Khmer happened during the mid 1990s when the Khmer Church had a vision to multiply.

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[9] Don Richardson. *Eternity in their Hearts.* (Ventura, Ca, Regal Books. 1984), 66-69.

[10] Hattaway, xv.

There have been tremendous mission successes in Theravada Buddhist countries, but most of the successes have been among animistic tribal peoples like the Karens, Chins, Kachins of Myanmar, the Khumu, and Hmong of Laos and the various "Montenyard" tribes of Vietnam, but not among the Theravada Buddhist majorities of these countries.

One of the most documented examples of an indigenous Church Planting Movement in the Theravada Buddhist world happened in Northeastern Thailand among the *Isaan* people. The term *"Isaan,"* means northeast in the Thai language, but the people call themselves "*Lao.*" They speak the Lao language, which according to them is an older language and culture than Thai. Covenant Free missionary, Jim Gustafson, who worked with the Thai Covenant Church was one of the pioneers in with the Isaan. Between 1974-93, 280 churches multiplied among the *Isaan* through the Thai Covenant (*Phra khun* in Thai) Church network, with 30 mother churches and 250 daughter churches.[11] Today there are over 330 churches in this network.[12] Throughout this paper I will cite this case study and draw parallels between the Isaan Movement and the movement that I am currently involved with in Myanmar. Unlike some members in the Isaan Buddhist Background Movement, believers in this movement in Myanmar do not call themselves "New Buddhists."[13] The movement in Myanmar can be categorized as C3 to C4 (see appendix 2). The reason that the Myanmar movement identify themselves with Christianity is because Buddhism is seen as corrupted for partnering with the military junta. In Thailand, Buddhism is seen as the primary social glue in a relatively prosperous country and Isaan believers do not wish to be identified with the West especially in regards to religion.

Most cross-cultural workers have simply overlooked or have chosen to ignore the fingerprints of biblical truth on the Theravada Buddhist worldview or they ignore how the Holy Spirit is speaking through new believers. Out of fear of syncretism (dual allegiance), most church planters believe that everything in Buddhist culture is of Satan. Others choose

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[11] Paul DeNeui. Personal interview with author, Chiang Mai, Thailand, June 2003. For a good C-5 perspective see DeNeui's, "Contextualizing with Thai Folk Buddhists." Appendix A. Presentation for SEANET March 18-19 2002. The older leadership in the Evangelical Covenant "Grace Church" can be classified as C5.

[12] Patrick Johnstone & Jason Mandryk. *Operation World* (Paternoster Lifestyle Pub., Wayneboro, Ga. 6th ed., 2001), 619.

[13] DeNuei, interview.2003

to ignore Buddhism because many English speaking Buddhists that they meet are simply ignorant of their own belief system and culture. Buddhism is a force to be reckoned with and its barriers are real. However, it does have several bridges that we will look at carefully.

STORIES THE BUILD BRIDGES

Siddhartha Gotama was born in 643 BC along the edge of the Ganges River Basin. Nineteenth century philosopher, Karl Jaspers, coined the term, "The Axial Age" to describe the time between 800-300 BC when masses of peoples were on the move and distant kingdoms were starting to interact with each other. This was the time when many world religion leaders started to proclaim new ideas that have later become the foundation of many world religions. Zoroaster in Persia, Confucius and Lao-tzu in China, Pythagoras in Greece, Mahavira of Jainism in India, Gotama, and the Jewish Prophet Daniel all lived during this time and were calling for reform of the various priest-craft structures who were ruling their day.[14]

The God of Israel had warned His people that if they did not obey His instructions then they would be scattered among the nations.[15] After 586 B.C. this warning became a reality because Israel was led into sin by her kings and thus were living in the nearby kingdom of Babylon. God told the Prophet Jeremiah that this captivity would last about seventy years. God allowed a young Jewish man to become a high-ranking official in the Babylonian Empire, which later became the Persian in 438 B.C. This Empire stretched from the lands of the Cush (modern Ethiopia and Sudan) all the way into India.[16] The Persian Empire had great influence on the commerce of central India especially along the Ganges River basin. This basin stretches from the Hindu-Kush Mountain Range in Afghanistan all the way to Calcutta and Bangladesh to the east. The Ganges basin was an important trade route not only for goods, but also for news and religious concepts. When the Persian King, Darius, opened the door of the lions' den in which he had placed his favorite Jewish administrator the night before, he saw that Daniel's God was the Most High God. He decreed that every tribe, language and people throughout His land must fear and worship the God of Israel.

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[14] Karen Armstrong. *The Buddha*.(Weidenfield & Nicolson Publishing. Great Britain. 2000),12.

[15] Deut. 26:64.

[16] Esther 1:8; 8:9.

By 586 B.C. all of the major Jewish prophets had foretold the coming Messiah who would also be the Savior of all of the nations. By this time the Law that God had given Moses had also been preached in all of the cities of the known world.[17] It is highly likely that Gotama heard some truths about the God of Israel. There were quite a few Jewish traders who carried the truths of God far into India and China.[18] Gotama was from the royal educated class and surely was educated in the most well spoken language of the time, which was Persian.

There are numerous similarities between Buddhism and Christianity that disciples of both religions can easily detect. For example,

- Theravada Buddhists observe a Sabbath.
- Buddha taught; do not kill, do not steal, do not commit adultery,
- and look for another coming Buddha who will judge the world of its sin
- and be the loving Lord of Compassion.
- When this Buddhist Messiah comes, the world will end with fire.
- It is very possible that Gotama got these teachings from the Jewish prophet's messages through the Decree of the Persian King.

When Buddhist and Hindus hear the teachings of Christianity they often make the claim that as Christianity came after the founding of their religions, then it most be concluded that Jesus Christ learned Hindu and Buddhist teachings in Tibet and Kashmir. They claim that he most likely learned this during the so called, "lost years" between the ages of twelve and thirty when the gospel does not speak of Jesus' whereabouts.

If one is to think that Christianity began with Christ, then this argument would be logical but Jesus movement predated His coming by His own account, "Abraham looked forward to my day and was glad" and "before Abraham was, I AM." [19]

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[17] Acts 15:31.

[18] Kirk Franklin. 2002. "Jewish Diaspora in Asia." Wycliffe Missiological Articles. www.wycliffe.org.au/html/missiological_articles/missiological_article001.htm.

[19] John 8.

It has been publicized in missiological circles about the existence of a certain detailed prophecy of the Coming Buddha with nail pierced hands and feet. All Buddhist are generally aware of the details that I mentioned in the previous section, but almost none are aware of the above "nail pierced prophecy." My friends have this " nail pierced prophecy," but as of yet they have not yet used it in presenting the gospel to Theravadas simply because the common people have such little knowledge of it, also, they are seeing success through another presentation which I will discuss later.

Several missionaries in Thailand were confronted by the Thai Religious police in 2000 and warned not to publish this story any more. Paul Wagner* told me that he once read this scripture with his own eyes in Wat Phra Sing in Chiang Mai, Thailand.[20] (Paul Wagner and Lao Pastor Inta Chanthavongsok both use the same source from Wat Phra Sing in Chiang Mai. Wagner cites *The Sutta Pitaka*, No. 26, which is part of the *Dighanikaya* collection of the first thirty-four *Suttas*. The *Dighanikya Sutta* mentions the Coming World Savior, "AriyaMettria." However the detailed description about the pierced hands and feet is missing from this scripture.

Once this scripture is found the source should be clearly cited including which basket of Buddhist scripture it is found. Once located, the Pali source with English translation should be placed on the internet where no authority can stop its spread.

Theravada Buddhism entered Thailand and Burma through the Mon people. The "prophecy" says that it is from Mon-Khmer scripture. It is reported that this scripture is being hidden in a monastery in a township formerly part of the Mon Kingdom. It was removed from the Buddhist tablets in Mandalay in 1879 at the Fifth Buddhist Council, because it was considered a threat to the Buddhist religion. I have possession of a hand copied English translation from a converted monk who gives a report of this scripture and how it led to his conversion. The Burmese pastor who showed me this report said that this

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[20] Paul Wagner* (not real name), Personal interview with author, Chiang Mai, Thailand, June 2002.

converted monk disappeared after he "de-robed" (publicly left the Sangha).[22] This Burmese version of the "prophecy" is slightly different from the "nail pierced prophecy" mentioned above.

The First and Greatest Barrier

Many western cross-cultural workers have speculated that the reason why Theravada Buddhists have been so unresponsive to Christ is because of their lack of a pre-Buddhist term for the Most High God. It is my understanding that the crucial issue is not the doctrine of God or a pre-Buddhism word for the Most High God, such as the Chinese, *Shang di* or the Korean *Hana-nim* terms, but something else that mission workers have been overlooking or misunderstanding.[23] Surprisingly, there is something even greater than Buddha in the Theravada worldview that must be addressed in order for Buddhists to understand the gospel.

There seems to be a black hole in Theravada Buddhism. This hole is none other than the Christian doctrine of heaven. According to the Buddhist background leadership that I work with, this is key in unlocking the Theravada Buddhist worldview and calling Buddhists to repent, believe the Good News of Christ, salvation, and then calling them to become disciples of the Lord Jesus Christ. The stated goal of Buddhism is to enter into the cession of suffering, which is *Nibbana*. The Buddhist Background Church has decided to use the term "*Nibbana"* for heaven.

My Buddhist Background friends in Myanmar speak with one voice, concerning the use of this term when evangelizing Buddhist peoples. This term was entirely *their* choosing and not an outsider's attempt to contextualize the gospel. I did not even realize how they were winning their Buddhist friends until one year after their movement started. Again this was entirely indigenous decision. I only suggested adding the term "Golden City" or "Golden Shore" after discussing this issue with Dr. Phil Parshall, who is a recognized contextualization advisor. He showed me the importance of attaching "qualifiers" to old

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[22] Personal interview with an unamed prominent Burmese mega-church pastor. April 2006.

[23] Richardson, 65-69.

terms to give them new meaning. For example, attaching the term *Isa* (Jesus) to the Muslim term *jamat* (religious study group) creates a new meaning for the old term. An *Isa Jamat* is a "house church" in the Muslim context. Muslim Background Believers in South Asia are using this term in the largest movement of Muslims turning to Christ in the history of Christianity.

One way of getting to the heart and core of the Theravada Buddhist worldview is to ask the following question: "What is the Ultimate Reality to a Buddhist?"[24] Followers of Christ, of course, would answer the Ultimate Reality is the Creator and Sustainer of the Universe, whom we call, *God*. In Theravada Buddhism, *Nibbana*, is defined as The Only Absolute Truth.[25] Melford Spiro wrote several books on his anthropological studies of Burmese Buddhist worldview. Spiro says,

> The Contemporary Burmese Buddhist exhibits three points of view concerning the meaning of Nirvana (Nibbana)... A small group says that short of experiencing nirvana, nothing can be said about it (other than that it entails that absence of suffering). A second group says that although we cannot say what nirvana is, it is not extinction or annihilation. Some members of this group argue that although nirvana means complete extinction of the physical aspect of life, its spiritual aspect of the mind remains. Others insist that although mind, too, is destroyed, there remains a special kind of awareness. The third group—those who believe that nirvana means total extinction—is the largest." He quotes a Burmese (from the third group) as saying that in nirvana "nothing exists" —there is no mind, no soul, no body, no feeling of any kind." [26]

The Buddhist background church leaders do not agree with Spiro, that most Burmese Buddhist believe that Nibbana means annihilation of self. Since there is so much confusion over the correct meaning of *Nibbana* within Theravada Buddhism, it is understandable why this Church Planting Movement's leaders have taken advantage of the weakness in the crumbling wall of Buddhism.

The goal of both Hinduism and Buddhism is to be set free from the endless cycles of reincarnation. Both religions use the term *Samsara* to describe the endless cycle of re-

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[24] James W. Sire. *The Universe Next Door: A Basic Worldview Catalog.* 3rd ed. (Downers Grove: Intervarsity Press, 1997), 17.

[25] Sri Walpola Rahula, *What the Buddha Taught* (New York: The Gordon Fraser Gallery Limited Bedford First Publish revised edition,1967). 35.

[26] David Noss. *History of the World's Religions*. (9th ed. Upper Saddle River, NJ: Publisher Prentice Hall, 1996),182-183.

birth. Buddhism calls the release from *Samsara, Nibbana*. Hindus call this liberation, "*Moksha.*" *Nibanna* literally means "no burning."

Burmese and other Theravada Buddhists add an attachment onto the term Nibbana that means "Golden City, Golden Land," or the "Golden Shore." This ancient word shows that the modern interpretation of *Nibbana* has been changed to mean annihilation. These place name attachments contradict the annihilation definition, and can be translated as, "a place of no more suffering." It is only in *Nibbana* that evil craving (sin) ceases, and the soul has reached it *nicca* (peace or stability). Sri Lankan Buddhist scholar, Walpola Rahula, seems to agree with the second definition of Nibbana when he says,

> Because Nirvana is this expressed in negative terms, there are many who have got a wrong notion that it is negative, and expresses self-annihilation. Nirvana is definitely no annihilation of self, because there is no self to annihilate.[27]

Buddha's Third Noble Truth of the cessation of suffering or *Nibbana*

(No Burning) is directly related to the Second Noble Truth of *Samodea*. The second truth is described by Burmese Buddhists as a black fire burning inside of all people. The extinguishment that Buddha described is not concerning the *Atta* (Self), but the extinguishment of this black fire of sinful craving. Buddhist World missiologists, John R. Davis and Alex Smith, both define *nibbana* as, "extinguishment of self."

The Judson term for heaven *kaungkin* has come into question by the Buddhist background circle of believers because Judson does not seem to recognize the Theravada worldview of thirty-one levels of existence (see Appendix 2). Judson even seemed to ignore the Buddhist understanding of the cosmos. It was Judson's wife, Ann, who was the first to translate the Bible into the Thai script, and there seems to be a connection in that translation's key terms with the Burmese.

In the midst of doing evangelism among their own people, these Buddhist background leaders realized that Judson's term for Heaven is a barrier to clearly communicating the gospel to Theravadans. All Buddhists long to be set free from the cycle of rebirths and

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[27] Walpola. 37

achieve cessation of suffering. This is the stated goal of to true Buddhist teachings. Traditional Christians often ask Buddhist seekers, "don't you want eternal life in *kaung kin* (sky)?" Buddhist reply, "absolutely not!"[29] Buddhists desire to escape the endless cycle of suffering; however, they cannot do this as long as they have sinful cravings. Buddhists simply need to understand that heaven is a wonderful place where there is no more sin and suffering.

The Judson term for *heaven* can be described as a literal translation and is not a meaning based (dynamic) translation. The Buddhist background church leaders of the Thai Covenant Church agree with using the term *Nibbana* when sharing with Buddhists about salvation. Although many members use the Buddhist term, *sawaan in* combination with *"Nibban*" to describe salvation to Theravada Buddhists in the Laotian and Thai languages, this is not an acceptable translation according to the Buddhists Background leaders in Myanmar. According to Thai Buddhist scholar Boonchuay Doojai, the Thai Christian term for heaven, "*sawaan,*" refers to the six celestial abodes of the thirty-one levels of existence that are just above the abode of mankind, (*Manussa Bhumi)*. Althogether, these abodes are commonly called the "Seven Sawaans" in Thai. He also says that *sawaan* is still caught up in the endless cycle of Samsara.[30] Christians do not seem to understand that there are twenty-six "heavens" above earth and the four hells in the Theravada view of the cosmos. There are in fact thirty-one levels of existence in the Theravada worldview. It can be said that the Theravada *stupa* or *chedi* sometimes called *pagoda* is a map of the cosmos. The king of the demons, *Man Nat* (Satan), lives above the abode of humans. When a Burmese Christian proclaims Jesus to be the way to *kaung kin*, Buddhist understand *kaung kin* to be under the rule of the Evil One. (see Appendix 1)

A third possible option to communicate the concept of salvation and Heaven would be to simply use the attachments, "Golden City, Golden Land, or Golden Shore" rather than using the controversial term, *Nibbana*. Judson used these terms as attachment in several songs that he wrote describing our final destination.

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[29] U Tint Lwin, "Contextualization of the Gospel for Theravada Buddhists in Myanmar." (PhD. diss., Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 1997), p. 108.

[30] Email discussion with Theravada scholar Doojai. August 2006.

Clarification from the Hindu context

Indian church multiplication coach and cancer surgeon, Victor Choudhrie, said the 100,000 house churches that he leads, use the term *Moksha* to help Hindus understand that Jesus is the way to (liberation) salvation. He says, *"Moksha* or *Nirvana* means release from the bondage of the cycle of rebirths. These are acceptable terms and can be used for "the release" from the bondage of sin.

In Hinduism and Jainism *Moksha* is understood by devotees to be liberation from the Cycle of Reincarnation. *Paraloka* is more accurate," he means that it is more of a literal translation of "Heaven" instead of a dynamic translation just as with the Judson term for heaven *kaung kin.*

The Myanmar movements have had pictures drawn of a Golden City floating on clouds. This is a common picture in Buddhist cartoon books for Nibbana and counters the Buddhists' weak argument that Nibbana means annihilation of the self. The Buddhist background leaders have incorporated these pictures into evangelistic tracts for distribution.

Sin

The Buddhist background leaders argue that the Judson term for sin, *aphyit*, does not communicate effectively to Theravada Buddhists the concept of missing the mark. *Aphyit* is understood as *crime,* and thus the majority of Buddhists do not consider themselves *criminals.* The concept of being a criminal before the Righteous Judge has much more acceptance in guilt based cultures as in Anglo-America. However in shame based communities, the idea that we have "lost face" is understood better in order to receive the gospel. Burmese Buddhists understand the term *kilesa*, which means "inward craving" or "inward evil desire." Buddhist background believers are calling heads of households to repent of their inward unintentional sin*, kilesa*, as well as any outward law breaking actions, *aphyit,* that they may have knowingly committed. Theravada Buddhists understand original sin.

Creation

There is a concept of creation in the Myanmar Buddhist worldview, but it is borrowed from Brahamism, and most Buddhists know little about this concept. When Christians use Chronological Bible Storying as a means of evangelism, they tend to run directly into Buddhist rejection. The monks tell the people that there is no use in thinking about such things. The Buddhist background church leaders suggest starting with Jesus then going backwards to discuss the truth of creation. This may be called, "unchronological" Bible storying. There are stories in Buddhism that are borrowed from Hindu thought, but again these stories are little known, they can be helpful after the message of salvation is shared.[32]

Stories of Blood Sacrifice

Sacrifice is practiced by all Theravada Buddhist, but it is practiced to appease hungry spirits. Most monks tell the people not to perform these ceremonies because they are not in accordance with true Buddhism. Although sacrifices may be a common practice, educated Buddhists do not understand sacrificial atonement stories in the Bible such as Abraham's sacrifice of Isaac. They often compare the Christian concept of sacrifice to their story of Alawaka. Alawaka, was an celestial ogre who had a taste for little children's blood.[33] The leaderships' opinion about this barrier is discussed later in this paper.

God's Righteous Judgment

When telling the story of the Israelites' escape through the Red Sea, Buddhist seekers were shocked to hear that this God of Love would kill the Egyptian army to protect His people. Church leaders agree that God's righteous judgment of sin is a crucial doctrine for new believers to understand, but that this gives Buddhist seekers particular concern. The Buddhist background leaders tell the same story but do not mention that the closing of the Red Sea and subsequent drowning of the unbelieving Egyptians was done by God. They

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[32] Russell Bowers Jr. "Folk Buddhism in Southeast Asia" Unknown publisher, Chiang Mai, Thailand, n. d.), 38.

[33] Agga Maha Pandita Bhaddanta Pannavamsa, *The Life of Buddha in Pictures*. (Printed by Ministry of Trade, Penang, Malaysia, n.d.), 47.

avoid this part and save it for after believers become more mature in their faith. The church leaders claim that this is a serious barrier to avoid for a first time hearing of the gospel.

Karma's Merit vs. God's Grace

From early childhood the Buddhist mind is trained to believe that if one does wrong, "then you will get back what you sow." Buddhist background believers are taught the story of Christ healing the blind man at the pool of Siloam. In this story Christ disciples ask "who's sin caused this man to be born blind" [34] Of course believers must be taught that re-incarnation is not real, but we do not need to attack this barrier so early in the discipleship phase. Later on they will understand, "Man is destined to die once and then face the judgment." [35] The Buddhist background believers do not teach this until after baptism. They do, however, emphasize the absolute truth that salvation is accomplished by Christ alone.[36] Traditional evangelists often say, "Salvation is free," and that no merit (*kusla*) is involved whatsoever. Traditional evangelists often ask seekers to raise their hands if they want to "accept" Christ. This "accepting" Christ is not a biblical concept and often counts seekers as disciples. The test that our Lord gave as a good indicator or confirmation of a changed heart has occurred was that a new believer obey His command to be baptized. In Acts 2 the apostles did not count how many hands were raised or how many seekers said the "sinner's prayer," but they did count how many were baptized. Buddhist background believers are proclaiming, "Christ earned all the merit for anyone who believes in the Blessed News. It is by His merit that we are set free."

The Love of God

With all the talk of compassion and love that Buddhists promote, it would seem there would be no problem with the term "love" as Christians understand it; however, for the Theravada Buddhists there is no equivalent. In Theravada Buddhism there are four kinds

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[34] John 9:1-5.

[35] Hebrews 9:27.

[36] Eph. 2:8-10.

of love, *Mudita* (sympathetic joy), *Upeka* (overlooking, possibly meaning forgiving love) *Metta* (loving kindness) and *Karuna* (pity) .

The Burmese Bible translates *agape love* as a *chit chit metta.* Believers claim that this not an acceptable translation to a Buddhist audience because *chit chit metta* can mean sexual love. Another reason for this term being a barrier is that Buddhists view love is like attachment or desire.[37] The new church leaders have translated Christ's command to "Love the Lord your God with all your heart, soul, mind and strength," [38] (Luke 10:27) as "Put God first."

A Lawyer's Method
Sharing Christ with Sincere Buddhists

This method is still in development but comes from one of the most successful evangelist/ church planter trainers in Southeast Asia. He is a lawyer and this document tries to show his argument from Buddhism that no one can obey the law completely. Through this method Buddhist are shown that complete perfection is what true Buddhism demands. We have seen over one thousand Buddhists come to Christ since Feb 2004 and have seen 70% of those baptized by using this method. There have been 180 tiny underground house churches started up until this time. Most of these churches are the third or fourth generation. Counting beyond the fourth generation is proving to be a daunting task. The Lawyer's method is easily reproducible and understandable by villagers as well as educated urban people.

Some have objected that many Buddhist people have little knowledge of Buddhism therefore we should avoid talking about it. This is logical if we are trying to reach younger people who can leave their families and join westernized churches, but the Lawyer's Method is meant to be shared with respectable village and family leaders who are often the guardians of religion for their people.

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[37] U Tint Lwin. 98-100.

The person known as "The Buddha" taught "The Four Noble Truths" that all Buddhists are to believe. You can find these in any book on world religions or Buddhism. However, very few Buddhists can tell you about each of these four points because the monks cannot attain Nibanna by this way.

The First Noble Truth is that all of life is caught up in a constant cycle of suffering called *dukkha.* Humans are born, we get old, we get sick and we die. After death the cycle starts all over again. We return either as a human, a low spirit (*Nat*), or a high spirit (Brahmin), an animal, or as demon. All these beings live in the 31 Levels of Existence. (See map of the Theravada Buddhist World on Appendix A).

The Second Noble Truth is Evil Craving (*Samudaya*-Attachment)

The *Abidamma Pitaka* scripture describes this evil craving as a black fire burning inside of all mankind that must be extinguished. Buddhism teaches that people are born with original sin. Contrary to popular belief, Buddhism teaches that Nibanna cannot be attained by making merit. It is only attained by extinguishing the ten evil cravings (*The Ten Fires of Kilesa*). This is illustrated by the fact that Monks do not practice merit making. Merit making is practiced by the laity. They do this in order to get to a higher plane of existence in the 26 realms of the spirits. The six levels of lower spirits and 20 levels of higher spirits.

All mankind are born with 10 *Kilesa*. *Kilesa* is defined as defilement of the mind and heart. Buddhists are trying to extinguish this fire. The 10 Ducarita-evil deeds are: killing; stealing; committing adultery; lies; dissension; greed; planning to destroy others by trickery; verbal abuse; wrong doctrine; and idleness. Buddhism teaches that people can go to the spirit realms by avoiding these Ten Evil Deeds but no one can avoid doing these practically, because we have committed oral and mental sins. Buddhists are well aware that they have broken all of these laws, daily.

Most Buddhists would agree with Jesus teaching, "No one is good, only God" and Romans 3:23 "For all have sin and fallen of short of the glory of God." Buddha taught that the origin of suffering is sin and we can show our Buddhists friends that the oldest story in God's word clarifies this Noble Truth. God told the first man and woman, "If you eat this fruit, you

will die." The Third Noble Truth is that there is a place of no more sin and no more suffering. There is a debate within Buddhism about the exact nature of Nibanna (Nirvana), but the basic meaning is no more sin, no more death, and no more reincarnation.

Buddhism teaches that The Fourth Noble Truth is the key to being set free from the sins that keep Buddhists attached to the 31 Levels of existence, which are part of the impermanent cycle of reincarnation. This key is known as *The Eightfold Path.* These eight are: perfect (righteous) effort; perfect mindfulness; perfect concentration; perfect action; perfect livelihood; perfect effort; perfect mindfulness; perfect concentration

Buddha is basically teaching us that we must be 100% perfect in order to be set free from the cycle of sin and suffering. This is very bad news to Buddhists but is the heart of the teachings of the Buddha. According to Buddhist tradition only a few people have ever attained enlightenment and those were during the time of Gotama Buddha in India.

There are ways to bring Jesus up as equal to Buddha in the minds of Buddhists. A common frustration that many believers experience when their Buddhist friend says "Oh, Jesus is just like Buddha." When a Buddhist Person of Peace says this, it is a good sign that the Holy Spirit is working in them and has elevated Jesus to the status of the Buddha in their mind. We should trust that the Holy Spirit is elevating Jesus higher and higher in the mind of your Buddhist friend. Do not be discouraged. Use the keys of the Kingdom and believe that Jesus can open the eyes of your friend's heart.

In Buddhism perfection is attained through two levels of meditation. The first level of meditation is *Thamata bawana.* Buddhism says that by doing this meditation you will have great power to do magnificent things like fly through the air. The second level of meditation is called *Wipathana* (Vespassana) and once attained allows a person to get enlightenment. By this enlightenment Buddhists can realize Nibanna and they can become a Buddhist saint, *thu daw zin.*

However, there is no one to coach Buddhists to practice *Thamata* or *Wipathana* meditation because no Buddhists have reached sainthood since the time of Buddha. The only way that Buddhists can complete these two levels of meditation is that they receive coaching from

someone who has already completed these two levels. Only saints (*thu daw zin*), not ordinary people can teach the perfect way.

There are five levels that one must reach in order to attain Nibanna.

1) The first is level is *Bu To Zan* and all people alive today are at this stage.
2) *So Ta Pan*, (No one is known to have reached this stage yet since the days of Buddha)
3) *Sa Gah Gan*,
4) *An Nah Gan*,
5) *Ya han da* (*thu daw zin* or sainthood). *Yahanda (Aharat or Sainthood)* are the only ones who can enter Nibanna.

The Nine Powers of Buddha

1) He is Buddha
2) He knows the Four Noble Truths\
3) He has Miraculous Powers
4) He is the Teacher
5) He is greater than all humans and spirits
6) He knows all Buddhist doctrine
7) He deserves worship of all creation
8) He knows who is deserves to go Nibanna.

Jesus is greater than Buddha because He has the power to save the world from sin.

At this point the Lawyer presents the problem to his friends. "You have no one to coach you to Nibanna as a Buddhist, because there are no saints living today to help us. You have no means to get Nibanna, so we have to find a new way. In Buddhism we have lost our way in this step. It is very urgent for us to find a new way, because Buddha himself taught that Nibanna is the ultimate goal of all Buddhism. If this is so, let us have a look at a different way. Here is a new way. Jesus Christ is the Way for us to reach Salvation. He himself declared, 'I am the Way, the Truth, and I am life'"

The Lawyer and those who he has trained show their friends that Jesus Christ sets us free from the cycle of sin and suffering and is the way to salvation. He explains that Nibanna is equal to salvation in the Buddhist mind. The Lawyer starts to tell the story about the miraculous virgin birth of Jesus. The Lawyer says that if you tell the story of Creation to sincere Buddhists at this point, you will encounter numerous problems. A common barrier that Buddhists face with the Creation story is called the problem of evil in Christian theology. Buddhists will not understand WHY the Creator God would allow death to happen to His creation if it was only humans' fault. Buddhist really do not understand the sacrificial system in the Old Testament, so a wise and sensitive evangelist should start with Jesus and then go backwards. Please read the list of barriers with explanation in Appendix B.

The Lawyer illustrates the logic of the virgin birth of Christ to the Buddhist mind by sharing the story of Buddha's mother, Maya, and how she gave birth. There are many miraculous occurrences associated with the birth of the Buddha, so it impresses Buddhists when they hear of the miraculous events surrounding the birth of Christ.

1. Emphasize the magnificent great angelic host proclaiming the Savior's birth, and the tremendous distance that The Magi from the east traveled in order to find the Coming Promised One.
2. The flight to Egypt as a refugee, the slaughter of the innocents and Jesus' return to Nazareth.
3. The fulfillment of many prophecies.
4. John the Baptist announces that he is not even fit to carry His sandals.
5. At the baptism of Jesus the Holy Spirit descended on Jesus shoulder as a dove and a voice is heard. 'This is my Son and I am very pleased with Him."
6. Jesus heals the woman with an issue of blood
7. The Sermon of the Mount
8. Love and Forgiveness
9. Giving joyfully
10. Prayer. Matthew 6:5-15, Luke 11:2-4

11. Deny yourself and follow the Messiah like Jesus instructed the Rich young ruler to do. Matt. 6:19-21, Matt. 19:16-13, Mark 10
12. Practice the Lord's Supper like Jesus instructed in Matt. 26:26-28
13. Jesus' Sacrifical Death, Burial, and Resurrection.

It is very difficult for Buddhists to understand the sacrificial atonement of Christ. They believe that Jesus must have done bad things in his previous life in order to die like He did. You can explain the sacrificial atonement of Christ through three key stories of the pre-existing Buddha taken from the *Jataka Tales* in the *Sutan da Pitaka.*

Jivitadana (life-offering) is the term that you want Buddhists to understand about Christ's sacrifice. There are three suitable stories to illustrate this:

1) The Royal Rabbit's Life-Offering
2) Wei Thandara's ("The Generous King's") Life-Offering
3) Sa Din Seng Min's ("The White Elephant King's") Life-Offering

The Buddhist Story that illustrates the Resurrection of Christ is "Shin Mauk-gah-lan." This saint was Buddha's "right hand man" and was attacked by five hundred thieves. He was cut into very small pieces, but he rose again. Once Buddhists hear these stories they begin to understand that Buddha only saved himself, but Jesus saved all those who believe in Him.

- Story of His Ascension
- Story of the coming of the Holy Spirit.

These evangelists also take advantage of the current political situation and the Buddhist military government's claim that "We are the most Blessed people because we follow the most blessed religion." They propose the question, "If we are the most blessed religion then why is every country around Myanmar (even the Muslim ones) more prosperous and overwhelming financially blessed?" They then propose, "We can only concluded two reasons for this, either we are following our Buddhism in the wrong way or we are following the wrong religion." The evangelist stops here and waits to see if hearts and minds are open. If so then he knows that the rock of Buddhism has been removed. Again, other Buddhists from rural villages are using this same method and are starting multiplying churches. Even though this is happening we agree that this argument needs to be simplified

and have made easily reproducible pictures to explain this simple concept. (See appendix 3). One of the primary church leaders has written a book with an educated monk discussing the claims of Christ and Buddha for discussion presenting the argument above.

It is the expressed vision of the leaders of this movement to call seekers out of Buddhism. They believe that calling themselves "Messianic Buddhist" (C 5 contextualization category) would bring Christ down to the level of Buddha. I have repeatedly heard seekers first proclaim, "Oh this is just like Buddhism" half way through the Lawyer's Method presentation, however by the end they state, "This is completely different, I want to follow Christ." I will discuss how God is reaching Folk Buddhist below.

Teach All Nations to Obey All My Commands

Buddhist Monks are taught to practice Ten Precepts of Buddha.

These are: refrain from destroying life; do not take what is not given; abstain from unchasity; do not deceive; abstain from intoxicants; eat moderately and not after noon; do not look on at dancing, singing, or dramatic spectacles; do not use garlands, scents, unguents, or ornaments; do not use high or broad beds; do not accept gold or silver.[42]

Since believers are taught that we are a new priesthood of believers or a *New Sangha* (monkhood). The following are ten activities that we are using to guide new Buddhist background believers to help them make disciples of others as our risen Lord commanded. These are basically the last thing that Christ commanded to His followers at His ascension and what the first believers were doing in Acts 2:37-47.

We call these **the "10 Commands of the Risen Christ."**

1. **Repent**--Story of the prodigal Son. Mark 1:15, Luke 15:11-31.
2. **Believe** the Good News. Story of Christ betrayal, death and resurrection. Luke 22:39- 24:12.
3. **Receive** the Holy Spirit. John 20:22.

[42] Noss. 171.

4. **Baptized** new believers to confirm repentance. We use the term for the monk's ordination ceremony for baptism. Sometimes the believers add "Christ" to this term. Story of Jesus, Ethiopian and Philippian jailure's baptism. Matt. 28:20. Acts 8.
5. **Practice the Lord's Supper**. Myanmar Buddhist have a ceremony when they make covenants. Also brides and bridegrooms have a special ceremony and we use these terms interchangeably. Story of the Last Supper Matt. 26:26 and I Cor. 11:23.
6. **Love God,** neighbor and even enemies. This command includes forgiveness.This term is interpreted as the Buddhist doctrine of love but in obedience to Jesus. Good Samaritan Luke 10:25-37, Unmerciful Servant, and the 37 One another teachings in the letters of Apostles.
7. **Pray everyday** in Jesus name in relationship with the risen Lord. Jesus' instructions on prayer to our Father. Luke 11:1-13.
8. **Give** joyfully for Christ mission. Share the story of the Poor Widow's mite.
9. **Deny yourself and follow the risen Christ**. Story of Paul's endurence even in the face of death. Acts 20
10. **Make disciples of Christ** by teaching them to lovingly obey the first seven commands. Share the Story of Wise and Foolish Builders. Story of Four Seeds Mark 4. Story about the first church who practiced the above commands of Jesus, Acts 2:37-47. "If you love Me you will obey my commands" John 14:21. "I have all authority… teach all nations to obey all of my commands, and I am with you always!" Matt 28:19-20.

If we take the previous command literally then we must teach new believers and leaders to obey all of Christ commands. New believers are being trained in storying all of His commands (summarized) and are training other multiplying house church leaders. It would be ideal to train them to story one lesson per meeting, having them report about who they trained and what happened each time they trained others.

Music

The house church leaders have made these ten commands of Christ into a song using their traditional style and instruments. Ethnomusicology is the study of how to help indigenous peoples to maintain and redeem their traditional forms of worship. The vast majority of churches in the Buddhist world do not use traditional music except on special occasions. To my knowledge this movement is the only church in Myanmar to worship Jesus through traditional music and forms on a regular basis.

All of the one hundred new Buddhist Background Churches that have been started in the since February 2004 use the *Geezee* bell in their worship meetings. Buddhist all over Myanmar use this bell to worship in their homes. The new Buddhist Background believers have declared this bell to be their bell of Liberation from the cycle of reincarnation and from hell. Buddhist Background Believers reported to me that when a Buddhist sees and hears another Buddhist praying without using the *Geezee* Bell then it means that he or she is praying to a bad spirit for manipulation of that spirit.

When the bell is struck three times, in the name of the *Buddha, Dharma* and the *Sangha* then everyone knows that it is the person is talking to a good spirit. The new Buddhist Background Believers are hitting this bell in the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. They hit the *gezee* three times as an invocation and at the end of a worship service as the benediction. New believers all say "*Thado*" (*sadhu* in Pali), three times instead of saying the Judeo-Christian term, "Amen." This term is also being used by the Thai Covenant Churches among the Isaan as well as in three other Buddhist Background Believing networks of churches in Thailand.[43]

Turning Buddhist Barriers into Stepping Stones

Paul noted that the Greeks of Athens were very devoted to their religion and were not lacking in zeal for their beliefs. He quoted their own scholars and writings from their holy places. He used their own understanding of truth to bring the story of Christ to their minds. Everyone working with Theravada Buddhists needs to pay attention to this principle in Acts 17. There are typically three ways Christians approach Buddhists; first they usually ignore Buddhism. This approach does work with many, but it has not led to one single movement

[43] Paul DeNeui, Chiang Mai, Thailand, 2003. Personal interview with the author.

in the Buddhist world. Another method that Christians tend to employ is directly attacking the Buddha and Buddhist doctrine the way Adoniram Judson sometimes dealt with the hard-hearted Burmese. Judson made an all out assault on the deity of Gotama in his track "The Golden Balance." In this track he pointed out the hypocrisy of the Burmese in their hatred for Indians while still worshiping an Indian, Gotama.[44]

The apologetic approach, when use evangelistically does not tend to work with Buddhists, Muslims or Hindus in comparison to the success of what I call, "the apostolic approach." Apologetics is meant to help believers to reinforce their understanding of the faith so that when seekers and opponents attack, then believers can give a thoughtful, Spirit-filled reply. As good as this approach is, it has a miserable track record in bring seekers to Christ. The apostolic evangelistic approach finds truths to build bridges of understanding between opposing views.

The roughly 400,000 baptized converts in Bangladesh take a remarkable loving attitude towards Mohammad. They use the very words of Mohammad that point to Christ by using the Koran as a bridge. A Bengali evangelist asks listeners, "Do you follow the word of Mohammad?" The listeners predictably respond, "of course we do!" Then the evangelist asks, "Why don't you read the New Testament (*Injil*) and follow Jesus or *Isa*? According to Bengali believers, Mohammad lifted Jesus up higher than himself and far above all other Prophets." This usually leads to whole families responding to Christ and new churches starting through household leaders.

In Thailand the Thai Covenant Church older leaders do not call themselves Christians but "*Children of God."* They use the story of the Coming Buddha, and they use the very words of Buddha to point to "the Coming One."[46] Lifting up Gotama, instead of putting him down is a more biblical approach to take than the ignoring and attacking approaches with Buddhists.[47]

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[44] James Khong "Bible Translation issues with the Judson Standard Version" (Master of Miss. diss., Fuller Seminary, Pasadena, Ca. 1998), 3.

[46] Paul DeNeui, 2003, Chiang Mai, Thailand. Interview with the author.

[47] Acts 17:13-34.

Jesus also said, “Unless your righteousness does not surpass the righteousness of the Pharisees then you cannot enter the Kingdom of Heaven.” This is the connection point with Buddhism. The key question is, “How does one achieve this?” Jesus’ answer is, “With man this is impossible, but with God all things are possible!” Only through Christ’s righteousness being imparted to Buddhist through his death on the cross and resurrected life living through us can we become the Righteousness of God. Most Buddhists practice making merit, and they think that they are getting many merits by doing Buddhist activities; but according to true Buddhism, this is not enough.

Bridge Terms for Buddhist

“Therefore be as shrewd as snakes and innocent as doves.”[48] While challenging a new Buddhist Background pastor to follow Christ in a Buddhistic way. He replied, “Yes, even the snakes and lizards do that! They blend into the background for safety and for offensive maneuvering.”

There is a tremendous need to not make it difficult for large numbers of Buddhist to come to Christ in a relatively short time. Missionaries in the Muslim world have identified common contextualized or indigenized terms based on Arabic and Persian term that help Muslims keep more of their cultural identity than if they joined non-Muslim background Churches in Islamic countries. With the publication of several contextualized Bibles across the Islamic world, Muslim peoples are responding like never before to the Good News. Those working with Theravada Buddhist would be wise to pay attention to these recent successes. Having a unified, contextual language is one of the greatest needs. The best way to analyze these terms is inside an obedient and naturally multiplying network of interconnected churches.

[48] Matthew 10:13.

Terms	Proposed terms in Burmese
Church—*ekklessia* (the call out ones)	*Chritdaw wine*
Bapitism/to Baptize	*Shin Phyu-Ya Han Khan Bwe*
Heaven-*ouranous*/paradise	*Nibban Shwe Byi, or simiply Shwe Khan Chin, or Shwe Myodaw by itself w/o Niban*
Pastors-*presb* , elders, Shepherds	*Wine Lu Gyi mya, Thot Kyaung thama*
Sin- Harmetia	*Kiletha (Kilesa-Pali)*
Lord's Supper/Communion	*Thitsa Phyu Bwe*
Angel	*Shwe Myo daw* Nat kaung Nat Myat

The Judson word for church is also a barrier term in this movement. Judson used two terms for "church." First is *paya kyoung* (church building), and the second is *athin-daw (congregation).* The first term in modern usage is directly related to a building, which is extra-biblical. The second term also is difficult because of the heavy affiliation with the extra-biblical Christian tradition of a non-participatory, sermon centered, worship service and organization.

Bridge Ceremonies

The Buddhist peoples hold a "*Shin Phyu*" (ordination celebration) when a young person enters the *Sangha* (priesthood). Participants parade the candidate through the neighborhood and hold a party in their honor. The Buddhist Background churches are the first group of churches in the Buddhist word to use the Buddhist term for ordination instead of the usually transliterated term, *baptism.* The Burmese Muslim community commonly use this term for their circumcision ceremony without any problem. Traditional Burmese Christians have also considered using this term since it is so culturally acceptable.[49]

[49] James Khong, 72.

Buddhists seem to accept this term; however, a monk friend of the leaders questioned, "isn't *shin phyu* for children only? How can it be used for adults?" The response was given, "Jesus said that unless you become like a little child you may never enter his kingdom." The participants are taught the Ten Precepts (commands) of Christ *Critdaw Say pha Thila* and are asked if they are willing to follow Christ unto death if need be. After a day or few hours of teaching all of participants agree together to obey Christ's commands not to earn merit but because Christ's merit is sufficient for them. The new resurrected life is emphasized and the participants say, *amaboni,* in unison, which means, *we agree!*

Bridge Holidays

In June 2005 the new Buddhist Background leaders decided to adapt the Buddhist calendar instead of blindly following the Greco-Roman animistic calendar. The leadership took note that Christmas was not Jesus real birthday. The first churches decided to reclaim the animist holidays in the name of Christ so that the faithful would not be tempted to fall back into their old lifestyle of attending pagan worship and pagan ceremonies on those days. The first believers grace-filled example ought to be claimed by new Asian churches as the right way to be a truly indigenous church and not a mere syncretistic copycat of the western church.

New Year's Celebration

The Water Festival is the time of year when Theravada Buddhists celebrate New Year's Day. This holiday does not have a direct connection with Buddhism but rather with Brahamism. This weeklong celebration usually takes place in March or April and is a cool welcome in the midst of the hot and dry season. The Buddhist Background network of churches have decided to claim this holiday as their Easter Week. These believers have not thrown out the Christian calendar but are adjusting and augmenting it. It was pointed out to them that the church celebrated New Year's day on Easter for thousands of years on the day that Christ rose from the dead, and that New Year's day was only changed to January a few hundred

years ago. [50] It is yet to become clear how the church will appropriate other ceremonies like the harvest ceremony and other Buddhist ceremonies in the name of Christ outsiders will have a lot to learn from this indigenous approach.

October New Moon Festival

The Myanmar Buddhist full moon festival of *Thadingyut* is annually celebrated to mark the end of the Buddhist lent and the end of the rainy season. On October 6, 2006 the new Buddhist background house church networks decided to use their old forms but redeem these forms with a new hope for this ancient festival. It can be said that *Thadingyut* has three parts.[51] The day starts off with Buddhist devotees attending an early meeting at the monastery with sermons about the teachings of the *Abidhamma* (The third basket, and most philosophical, of Theravada Buddhist scriptures). Most attendees do not understand the chanted Pali scriptures. At this time believers in Christ meet together to read or recite Matthew 24:1-51, which describes the signs of the return of Christ at the end of the age.

Although there will be bad times in the last days, Christ's commands His disciples to have the hope of His coming. Another sign of the last days should be read along with the previous passage which is 2 Timothy 3:1-5. This scripture reminds us that in the last days before Christ's return that people will be disobedient to their parents and this leads to the next ceremony.

The third ceremony usually takes place in private between parents and their children, abbots and their monks, and teachers and their students. *Gau doubt Bwe*, as it is called in Burmese, allows the participants to offer and receive forgiveness. This has not been forbidden for believers in Christ but has been encouraged. The only stipulation was that believers do not worship others but honor them. Believers read Ephesians 5:8-33, 6:1-4 which describes the new system for relationships for children of the light.

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[50] Brian Hogan. 2004. Perspectives Lectures. https://www.cpcoaches.org. (accessed June 1, 2004).

[51] Khine Maung Nyunt, Myanmar Traditional Monthly Festivals, (Inwa Publishing House.Yangon, Myanmar 2001), 79-91.

The last ceremony is the best known part of the day the Festival of Lights. This ceremony is practiced to commemorate Buddha's descent from the *celestial abode of Tusita*. This *abode* is very different from the Christian doctrine of heaven and is still part of the thirty-one levels of the Theravada Buddhist cosmos. Candles are lit to light the way for Gotama's return. When he died, the Buddha told his followers that he would not be returning from *Nibbana*. However, our Lord Jesus commanded His disciples that they should keep watch for His return. He said that when He returns, He will take us back to His Fathers house. His Father's House is in heaven, which is described as a golden city where there will be no more tears, suffering, and sin. Believers bring one candle and sit in a circle. After an invitation prayer, the facilitator lights a candle and perform the passing of the light, while someone reads John 9:1-5, and Matthew 5:14.

Jesus told His disciples that while He was in the world He would be the Light, but that they would also be lights, which cannot and should not be hidden. While lights are burning and placed on plates on a stand in the middle, the circle of believers observe the Lord's Supper. It is explained that the multiplication of lights represents the multiplication of witnesses that bring light to this dark world. They have also told the story of the Ten Bridesmaids who were told to keep watch for the Bridegrooms return.[52] (Matthew 25:1-13; Matt. 5:14).

Believers held a feast to commemorate the feast that we will have together in heaven when the Lord returns. "I say to you that there will be many who come from the east and the west, and will take their places at the feast with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob in the (*Golden*) Kingdom…" [53] (Italics mine). In Theravada Buddhism, monks blow a conch shell to trumpet the return of Buddha from the *Tusita* (celestial abode, not heaven). If believers in Christ are comfortable with this they should be encouraged to do the same, for Our Lord is coming with the trumpet call of God and the voice of the archangel.[54] If time does not permit, then believers can just combine all three meetings together into one and read Matthew 25:1-13. There may have never been a holy day in the history of Christianity that

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[52] Matt 25:1-13; Matt. 5:14.

[53] Matt 8:11.

[54] Matt 24:31.

looks forward to the return of Christ. If there was any people and country that needed to hear the message of this hope, it surely is the peoples of Myanmar.

Visions and Dreams

One admitted weakness in the Lawyer's Method is that it does not address the spirit world. Even though this is true, God has recently been showing His power through dreams and visions. Church leaders have reported many stories of believers and seekers being greatly impacted by dreams and visions. The wife of the primary church planting coach had a vision of a great light coming to her as she rested one afternoon. The next day a she had a similar vision, but the light came closer and she saw a man in white. She assumed it was Jesus and became a believer. After telling several friends about her dream they put their faith in Christ.

Conclusion

The church in the Muslim world is growing about ten times faster than the church in the Buddhist world. This is in part due to cross-cultural and Muslim background believers sharing through family networks and disciple leaders behind the scenes. Therefore the multiplication pattern in the New Testament has been promoted more in the Islamic context. Most Buddhists do not threaten the lives of foreigners (there are however documented cases of Buddhists poisoning Christian missionaries and their native translators). Cross-cultural workers often indirectly impose their own foreigner culture on the new churches. This has led to churches in the Buddhist world that are overwhelmingly unBuddhistic! They ignore cultural forms that are biblically premissable and tend to syncretize western forms of Christianity with Asia worldviews.

The Myanmar movement's leaders have recently begun to translate their own Bible and believe that their own translation will be the beginning of a Bible Translation Movement (BTM) among the Theravada Buddhist peoples around them. The Judson Standard Version was truly foundational in unifying the Burmese tribal Christians, but it was not the work of Buddhist background believers. Also, it certainly was not translated in the context of a multiplying movement of Churches. Cross-cultural workers in countries where Church

Planting Movements have become common do not seem to appreciate the massive amount of time that goes into the monumental task of Bible Translation. Martin Luther with all of his accreditations and theological doctorates once wrote,

It was good that God allowed me to live to start the job of translating His word into my German language lest I might have went to my grave thinking myself to be an intelligent man. [55]

[55] Scott Munger, "Bible, Babel, Babble: The Foundation of Bible Translation." International Bible Society, www.ibs.org/niv/munger/BibleBabelBabble_en.pdf. (accessed June 2006).

Appendix 1
Three Levels of Authority for new churches

Adapted from George Patterson and Jonathan Campbell
www.paul-timothy.net

SPHERE OF AUTHORITY	DESCRIPTION	TRANSLATABILITY
Christ's Commands (The Core)	*Commands* are non-negotiable. Jesus Christ is our ultimate authority. Therefore, our first priority is to faithfully follow Jesus and fulfill His purposes (Mt. 28:19-20; John 14:15.21; I John 5:2-3).	Fully Translatable No Adaptation Non-Negotiable
Apostolic Patterns (The Application)	*Patterns* are principles and values in action. They are expressed in specific cultural contexts as behaviors, practices and lifestyles of first-century Christians that are normative (I Cor. 4:16-17, Phil 3:16-17: I Thess. 1:7-8; II Thess. 3:9).	Translate Contextualize To fit the culture
Church Practices (The Expression)	Church *practices* or traditions are culturally inherited and/ or established ways of thinking, feeling or doing. They should be tested according to the commands of Christ, biblical principles and then to cultural relevance (Mt. 15:3, 6; Rom 12:1, 2; Col 2:8).	Non-Translatable Culturally-Specific

Appendix 2

C1: Traditional Church Using Outsider Language

Many reflect Western culture. A huge cultural chasm often exists between the church and the surrounding Muslim community. Some Muslim background believers may be found in C1 churches. C1 believers call themselves "Christians."

C2: Traditional Church Using Insider Language

Essentially the same as C1 except for language. Though insider language is used, religious vocabulary is probably non-Islamic (distinctively "Christian"). The cultural gap between Muslims and C2 is still large. Often more Muslim background believers are found in C2 than C1. C2 believers call themselves "Christians."

C3: Contextualized Christ-centered Communities Using Insider Language and Religiously Neutral Insider Cultural Forms

Religiously neutral forms may include folk music, ethnic dress, artwork, etc. Islamic elements (where present) are "filtered out" so as to use purely "cultural" forms. The aim is to reduce foreignness of the gospel and the church by contextualizing to biblically permissible cultural forms. May meet in a church building or more religiously neutral location. C3 congregations are comprised of a majority of Muslim background believers. C3 believers call themselves "Christians."

C4: Contextualized Christ-centered Communities Using Insider Language and Biblically Permissible Cultural and Islamic Forms

Similar to C3, however, biblically permissible Islamic forms and practices are also utilized (e.g., praying with raised hands, keeping the fast, avoiding pork, alcohol, and dogs as pets, using Islamic terms, dress, etc.). C1 and C2 forms avoided. Meetings not held in church buildings. C4 communities comprised almost entirely of Muslim background believers. C4 believers identify themselves as "followers of Isa the Messiah" (or something similar).

C5: Christ-centered Communities of "Messianic Muslims" Who Have Accepted Jesus as Lord and Savior

C5 believers remain legally and socially within the community of Islam. Somewhat similar to the Messianic Jewish movement. Aspects of Islamic theology which are incompatible with the Bible are rejected, or reinterpreted if possible. Participation in corporate Islamic worship varies from person to person and group to group. C5 believers meet regularly with other C5 believers and share their faith with unsaved Muslims. Where entire villages accept Christ, C5 may result in "Messianic mosques." C5 believers are viewed as Muslims by the

Muslim community and refer to themselves as Muslims who follow Isa the Messiah.

C6: Small Christ-centered Communities of Secret/Underground Believers

Similar to persecuted believers suffering under totalitarian regimes. Due to fear, isolation, or threat of extreme governmental/community legal action or retaliation (including capital punishment), C6 believers worship Christ secretly (individually or perhaps infrequently in small clusters). C6 (as opposed to C5) believers are usually silent about their faith. C6 believers are perceived as Muslims by the Muslim community and identify themselves as Muslims.

John Travis, "The C1 to C6 Spectrum: A Practical Tool for Defining Six Types of 'Christ-centered Communities' ('C') Found in the Muslim Context," *Evangelical Missions Quarterly* (October, 1998): 407-408.

Appendix 3

31 abodes of Existence
According to Theravada Buddhism
Adapted from Suvano Mahathera
www.accesstoinsight.org

I. The Immaterial World *(arupa-loka)*

31 Neither-perception-nor-non-perception (nevasannanasa	84,000 Mahakappas	The inhabitants of these realms are possessed entirely of mind. Having no physical body, they are unable to hear Dhamma teachings.
30 Nothingness *(akiñcañ̃ayatanupaga deva)*	60,000 Mahakappas	
29) Infinite Consciousness *(viññanañcayatanupaga deva)*	40,000 Mahakappas	
28 *akasanañcayatanupaga deva*	2,000 Mahakappas world existences	

II. The Fine-Material World *(rupa-loka)*

27*. (akanittha deva)*	16,000 Mahakappas	These are the five Pure Abodes *(suddhavasa),* which are accessible only to non-returners *(anagami)* and arahants. Beings who become non-returners in other planes are reborn here, where they attain arahantship. Among its inhabitants is Brahma Sahampati, who *begs the Buddha to teach Dhamma to the world*
26. *(sudassi deva)*	8,000 Mahakappas	
25. *(sudassa deva)*	4,000 Mahakappas	
24. *(atappa deva)*	2,000 Mahakappas	
23. *(aviha deva)*	1,000 Mahakappas	
22. *(asaññasatta)*	500 Mahakappas	Only body is present; no mind.
21. (*vehapphala deva)*	500 Mahakappas	Beings in these planes enjoy varying degrees of bliss.
20. *(subhakinna deva)*	64 Mahakappas	
19. (*appamanasubha deva)*	32 Mahakappas	
18. (*parittasubha deva)*	16 Mahakappas	
17. *(abhassara deva)*	8 Mahakappas	
16. A*ppamanabha deva*	4 Mahakappas	
15. *Parittabha deva bhumi*	2 Mahakappas	
14. *Maha brahma bhumi*	1 Mahakappas	One of this realm's most famous inhabitants is the Great Brahma, a deity whose delusion leads him to regard himself as the all-powerful, all-seeing creator of the universe.
13. *(brahma-purohita deva bhumi (abode)*	½ Mahakappas	Beings in these planes enjoy varying degrees of bliss.
12. B*rahma-parisajja deva bhumi (abode)*	1/3 Mahakappas	

III. The Sensuous World *(kama-loka)*

Thai: *Sawan*
Levels 6-11

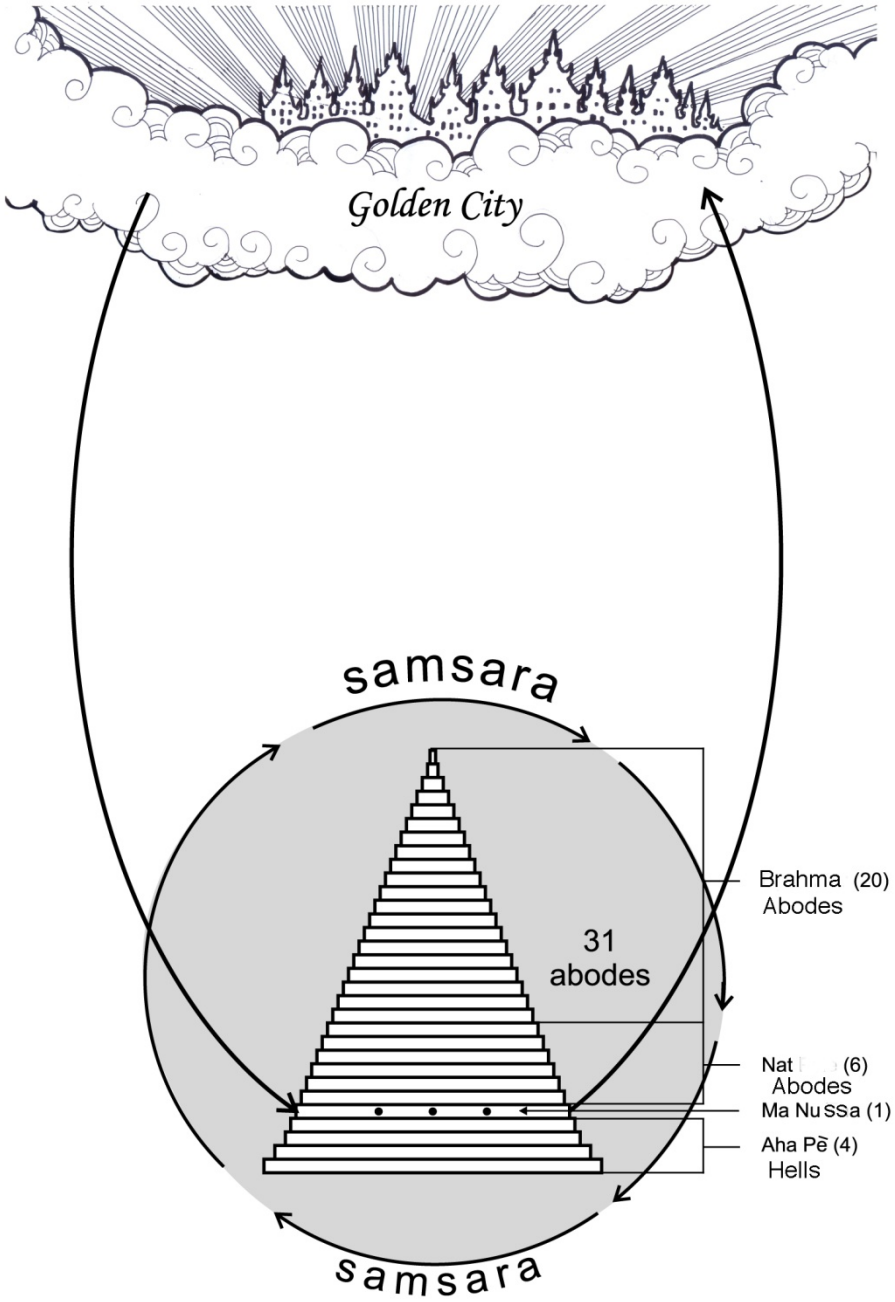
(11) *Paranimmita-vasavatti deva heaven*	9,216 million years	Mara, the Evil One lives here. Notice that this abode is far above the Christian term for Heaven in all Theravada Buddhist countries
(10) *Nimmanarati deva heaven*	2,304 million years	These devas delight in the sense objects of their own creation
(9) *Tusita deva heaven*	576 million years	Bodhisattas abide here prior to their final human birth. The coming Buddhist Messiah, Metteya, is said to dwell here.
(8) Yama devas heaven	144 million years	Ruled by Suyama deva, the devas who here are free of all difficulties.
(7) Tavatisma heavens of 33 devas (gods)	36 million years	Sakka (Indra), a devotee of the Buddha, presides over this heaven
(6) Catumaharajika	9 million years	Home of the *gandhabbas,* the celestial musicians, and the *yakkhas,* tree spirits of varying degrees of ethical purity. The latter are analogous to the goblins, trolls, and fairies of Western fairy tales.
(5) *Ma nu ssa Loka* (Human world). According to Theravada Buddhism	↑ The Christian term for "Heaven" in all Theravada Buddhist countries is at the top of/above this level. 70-80 years. **You are here,** for now, according to Theravada Buddhism	the attainment of stream-entry *(sotapatti)* guarantees that all future rebirths will be in the human or higher realms.
(4) Asuras (demons)	These "Titans" that dwell here are in constant conflict	
(3) Petas (hungry spirits)	Ghost or unhappy spirits who wander the earth	
(2) Tiracchana (animals)	This realm includes all the non-human forms of life that are visible to us under ordinary circumstances: animals, insects, fish, birds, worms, etc.	

(1) Niraya (Hell) 8 levels of Hell	These are realms of unimaginable suffering and anguish. Should not be confused with the *eternal* hell proposed by other religions, since one's time here is — as it is in every realm — temporary.	

This diagram is occasionally drawn as a Buddhist stupa as in the diagram in Appendix 3

Appendix 4

A Theravada Buddhist's view of the Cosmos and understanding of Salvation



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